

education HARVARD INITIATIVE

■ By Kaverie Bamzai

In 1974, when Anand Mahindra, vice-chairman and managing director, Mahindra and Mahindra, was at Harvard, studying art and photography, he remembers tuning in to the CBS Evening News with Walter Cronkite and hearing about India testing a nuclear weapon. "I remember the woman sitting next to me saying, I thought India couldn't feed her hungry." Cut to recently when he returned from a meeting of the Harvard Business School (HBS) and one of the board members, the CEO of a large corporation, leaned across to him in the bus and said, "How come all Indians are so smart?" In 1989, when

Vikram Gandhi, managing director and global head of the Financial Institutions Group at Credit Suisse in New York, was at HBS, he was an oddity in a class of 800. "There were a handful of Indian professors and I was the only guy from India with a funny accent," recalls Gandhi. Now 15 per cent of the faculty is Indian and 38 of the 900 students who joined this year are from India or are of Indian origin. For the two men, the connection with

the 371-year-old university, the oldest and richest in the US, has become stronger since they graduated. Both are part of the seven-member Founders Club, which has pledged \$11 million (Rs 43 crore) to Harvard's South Asia Initiative (SAI), a university-wide entity charged with setting Harvard's academic agenda, funding student and faculty research, and optimising activities across various schools. The initiative was announced

DESTINATION

